to international criticism, and the lack of any real domestic pressure, allowed it to delay its response. Finally, in August, the local authorities in Rakhine agreed to bring twenty people to court for human trafficking.[110] This followed consistent denials by the regime that people smugglers were exploiting the misery of the estimated 150,000 Rohingya trapped in internally displaced persons camps. This limited shift of approach might be related to US concerns, documented in the 2015 *Trafficking in Persons Report*, which is particularly critical of the Myanmar authorities. The State Department's assessment is stark:

> Government officials are complicit in trafficking within Burma. Men, women, and children from ethnic areas, including the estimated 98,000 persons displaced by conflict in Kachin and northern Shan States and the estimated 146,000 displaced persons in Rakhine State, are particularly vulnerable to trafficking. Reports indicate some Rohingya women are subjected to sex trafficking in Rakhine State. Local traffickers use deceptive tactics to recruit men into forced labor on palm oil and rubber plantations or in jade and precious stone mines. Children are subjected to sex trafficking or to forced labor in teashops, the agricultural sector, and in begging.[111]

It is difficult to assess the extent to which the Myanmar authorities are active in forcing the Rohingyas to leave, rather than simply not intervening. While their usual first response is to try and ignore international criticism, adverse commentary, especially from powerful sources, does have some impact on their actions. The US Department of State's assessment that 'government continued law enforcement efforts to address cross-border sex trafficking, but did not make progress in holding significant numbers of traffickers, including public officials, criminally accountable for trafficking within the country'[112] perhaps sums up this ambiguity. On this basis the intended prosecution of twenty individuals may be little more than a necessary formal response to deflect external pressure, but it does support the view that external pressure can have some effect.

However, there is chilling evidence that Rakhine extremists may be involved at every stage in the process, not just in wanting to force the Rohingyas to leave. Reports suggest that some boats are crewed both by Thais and Rakhine Buddhists, as a recent Reuters article reported: 'They were guarded by 11 men with guns, he said. Most were Thai speakers but one was Rakhine, the majority Buddhist ethnic group in Rakhine State'.[113] If this is more widespread than an isolated incident, it indicates a very worrying trend. It would mean that Rakhine extremists are forcing the Rohingyas to flee, but not, as previously, as refugees, but as direct